



Entangled in election-related politics, the Indian Premier League moves to South Africa and raises questions about financial viability and logistical challenges

By Sharda Ugra

When the Indian Premier League (IPL) burst upon India last year, six noisy weeks of cricket in a mini-skirt, arm-in-arm with business and Bollywood with capacity crowds and roof-ripper ratings, it felt like revolution. Like something had unalterably changed the contours of the game that moves India and that India, for its part, moves too.

If IPL Season 1 was a watershed, Season 2 was supposed to be the summer of consolidation, with earnings expected at Rs 700 crore, an undisputed pre-eminence in the cricket and entertainment economy and an audience waiting for more.

Instead, with three weeks to go, the League opened several battle fronts at the same time, one against a powerful adversary, the Government of India. Now, in order to stay afloat, viable and relevant, the IPL has been forced to take much of the India out of its second season. It has, in fact, taken the unprecedented step of taking the League out of India, stitching up a deal with Cricket South Africa (CSA) to play surrogate, overseas host.

This is the first time in sport that a domestic sporting event has been held outside the country of its origin, from where it will be broadcast back to its main audience. Moving to South Africa may make the IPL seem like the ultimate flat-world sports event, where geography and boundaries are irrelevant in the face of a live television

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